

**Reg. the 8th edition of the Poshan Pakhwada will be observed 9th April secy-
till 23rd April 2026.**

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Anil Malik < secy.wcd@gov.in >

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To "Pallavi Jain Govil"<secy-ya@nic.in>

1 Attachment(s)

Dr. Pallavi Jain Govil.pdf

11.3 MB

Respected Madam,

Please find attached a D.O. letter dated 03/04/2026 from Shri Anil Malik, Secretary, M/o. Women and Child Development, Government of India, on the above subject with its enclosure.

Regards,

**Office of Secretary
Ministry of Women and Child Development
Government of India
Room No. 602 A-Wing, 6th Floor,
Shastri Bhawan, New Delhi 110001
Tel: 011-23383586,23386731**



अनिल मलिक, आई.ए.एस.
सचिव

Anil Malik, I.A.S.
Secretary

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सत्यमेव जयते

भारत सरकार
महिला एवं बाल विकास मंत्रालय
शास्त्री भवन, नई दिल्ली-110 001

Government of India
Ministry of Women & Child Development



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आज़ादी का
अमृत महोत्सव

3rd April, 2026

DO No.PA/92/2026-CPMU-Part(1)

Dear Secretary,

The Ministry of Women and Child Development (MWCD) celebrates Poshan Pakhwada every year in convergence with all stakeholders to improve nutritional outcomes in a holistic manner. The 8th edition of the Poshan Pakhwada will be observed across the country from 9th April till 23rd April 2026. This Pakhwada seeks to deepen the Jan Andolan by focusing on transformative theme "Maximizing Brain Development in the First Six Years of Life" and strengthen awareness among families and communities about practices that support healthy growth of children and development of their brain during infancy.

2. The following priority areas have been identified for focused action during the Pakhwada:

- i. Mother & Child Nutrition
- ii. Early Stimulation for Brain Development (0-3 years)
- iii. Play Based Education in Early Years (3-6 years)
- iv. Role of Parents and Community in Minimizing Screen Time
- v. Garnering Community Support for Stronger Anganwadis

3. I request you to kindly direct the Departments and Institutions/ Organizations concerned under your Ministry as well as your counterparts in the States and UTs to undertake suitable activities aligned with these thematic areas to encourage mass level community participation for promoting awareness on nutrition. The 14 Lakh Anganwadis located in all areas of the country will be the fulcrum of these activities.

4. I would further request you to kindly nominate a Nodal Officer (not below the rank of Director) from your Ministry/Department to facilitate effective coordination. Dr. Monika Singh, Director, Poshan Abhiyaan (Ph:23380013, e-mail: monika.singh@gov.in) will be the nodal officer from the MWCD.

5. A Concept Note on the Pakhwada is **enclosed**.

With regards,

Yours sincerely,


(Anil Malik)

Encl: As above.

Dr. Pallavi Jain Govil
Secretary,
Department of Youth Affairs,
Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports,
Room Nos.6201 & 6202, 6th Floor, Zone 2,
GPOA, Block-3, Netaji Nagar,
New Delhi-110023

CONCEPT NOTE

8th POSHAN PAKHWADA (9th – 23rd April 2026)

Maximizing Brain Development in the First Six Years of Life

A) Background

The Government of India's flagship nutrition program POSHAN Abhiyaan has successfully evolved into a nationwide Jan Andolan, fostering people's participation in improving nutritional outcomes. Over the years, the national campaign in the form of Poshan Maah and Poshan Pakhwada has strengthened awareness on maternal nutrition, infant and young child feeding practices, addressing anaemia, growth monitoring of children and community participation across millions of households in the country.

In 2025, the Ministry of Women and Child Development has celebrated 7th Poshan Pakhwada from 8th-22nd April, a two-week nationwide campaign aimed at promoting nutrition awareness, improving health outcomes and empowering communities. Through this Jan Andolan, focus was on reinforcing community engagement and fostering the empowerment of individuals and communities as a whole. The pakhwada was virtually launched on 8th April 2025 by Smt. Savitri Thakur, Hon'ble MoS in the Ministry of Women and Child Development. Field Functionaries and Officers from all 36 States and UTs have virtually joined the launch event.

Overall, 6.97 crore sensitisation activities were reported by all 36 States and UTs held in convergence with more than 18 partner Ministries/Departments around the following themes:

1. Focus on first 1000 days
2. Popularisation of beneficiary/ citizen module
3. Management of malnutrition through implementation of CMAM module
4. Healthy lifestyle to address Obesity in children

The 8th Poshan Pakhwada will reinforce the message that community-led action is central to ensure optimal nutrition and nurturing care during the first six years of life the most critical period for brain development in children. It will mobilise Anganwadi Workers, mothers, caregivers and communities across the country to intensify awareness generation and outreach during the Pakhwada period from 9th to 23rd April 2026.

B) Rationale

Scientific evidence indicates that more than 85% of brain development occurs by the age of six years, with the most rapid growth taking place during the first 1000 days – a crucial period for optimal brain growth, physical development and holistic well-being.

Recognizing the critical importance of care and nutrition for children in the early stage of life, the 8th Poshan Pakhwada seeks to deepen the Jan Andolan by focusing on a scientifically critical and transformative theme “Maximizing Brain Development in the First Six Years of Life” and strengthen awareness among families and communities about practices that support healthy growth and brain development.

It aims to shift the narrative from “nutrition for health” to “nutrition and early childhood stimulation for optimal brain development” through the following **Central Theme: Maximizing Brain Development in the First Six Years of Life.**

C) Proposed Major Focus Areas

1. MOTHER & CHILD NUTRITION

Evidence shows that pregnancy is a critical window influencing fetal brain development and long-term cognitive outcomes, with maternal nutrition and antenatal care as key determinants. Improved awareness can help ensure timely care, adequate diet and healthy practices among expectant mothers. Similarly, promoting optimal Infant and Young Child Feeding (IYCF) practices are essential for supporting holistic growth and development of children in the first 1000 days.

A: Breastfeeding: Breastfeeding is the first natural intervention supporting immunity and brain development.

B: Complementary Feeding: From six months onward, appropriate complementary feeding becomes critical to sustain rapid brain growth.

Activities may include –

- a. Poshan Pe Charcha (suggested topics- diet and care during pregnancy, importance of Ante Natal Care (ANC), weight gain during pregnancy, early initiation and exclusive breastfeeding, Timely & Age appropriate complementary feeding etc.)
- b. Poshan ki Kahani, Dadi Nani ki Zubani which includes peer learning, experience sharing at community level
- c. Awareness session on hazards of junk and packaged foods
- d. Recipe Demonstration on nutritious local recipes for pregnant women, lactating mother and children
- e. Cooking competition for promoting healthy food
- f. ANC camps for pregnant women
- g. Poshan rallies with participation of AWWs, beneficiaries, SHGs, and community members, using placards and catchy slogans to spread awareness on nutrition and health messages.

2. EARLY STIMULATION FOR BRAIN DEVELOPMENT (0-3 YEARS)

The first six years of life are very important, as a child's brain develops rapidly during this period. Affection, care, proper nutrition, and regular engagement with the children can significantly improve their thinking, speaking, and physical abilities which lays a strong foundation for lifelong learning.

Parents and caregivers play the most important role in early stimulation through simple activities at home. Talking, singing, playing, and responding to a child's sounds and actions help to build strong brain connections and support development.

Activities for early stimulation may include:

- a. Awareness sessions at AWCs for parents and family members on simple stimulation practices as per Navchetana framework (0-3 years).
- b. Home visits by AWWs to explain developmental milestones in a simple manner and help parents understand if the child is growing and developing well.
- c. Mother–Child Interaction Demonstrations
- d. Demonstrations of play-based learning using locally available materials
- e. Language Development Sessions
- f. Special Village Health, Sanitation and Nutrition Days (VHSNDs) focusing on linking nutrition, growth and brain development, along with early identification of developmental delays and timely referral.

3. PLAY-BASED EDUCATION IN EARLY YEARS (3-6 YEARS)

Parents often fear that play might lead to conflicts or time wastage, emphasizing the perceived importance of academic activities. Contrary to this belief, especially in the early childhood years, play serves as the primary avenue for learning. Learning can be fostered through various avenues such as talking, listening, using toys, child-friendly activities, and physical engagement.

Therefore, a play-based, activity-based and inquiry-based pedagogy is essential for promoting holistic development of children and preparing them for formal education starting from grade-I. Implementation of a play-based ECCE curriculum helps create engaging and child-friendly learning environment that support cognitive, social and emotional, physical, language, cultural and aesthetic development of children of age 3-6 years.

Activities for play-based education in early years may include:

- g. Sessions on importance of play and activity-based learning for children for their holistic development

- h. Sessions on importance of involvement of male caregivers in a child's development.
- i. DIY Toy Making Workshop – Involving parents and Anganwadi staff in making low-cost/no-cost home-made toys (e.g., flashcards, puzzles, stacking objects) using household items
- j. Sports and Dance Day (Motor Skills) – Promoting physical and motor development with active community participation.
- k. Numeracy and Creativity Day (Nanhe Kalakaar) – Hands-on activities to develop number sense and creativity, such as market role-plays, folk art demonstrations, puzzles and drama.

4. ROLE OF PARENTS AND COMMUNITY IN MINIMIZING SCREEN TIME

To address emerging challenges in lifestyle habits including increased sedentary lifestyle and excessive screen time, parents and community can play a key role in protecting early brain development by limiting screen time and promoting active lifestyles for optimal growth and cognitive development among young children. Setting screen-free routines and modelling healthy behaviour supports attention, language and cognitive development.

Activities may include –

- a. Counselling sessions on hazards of screen exposure
- b. Dissemination of video messages on safe screen limits and healthy digital habits,
- c. "No-Screen-Hour" or "Family Play Time" campaigns at the community level,
- d. Promotion of outdoor games, physical activities, sports and yoga
- e. Storytelling by grandparents to keep children away from screen

5. GARNERING COMMUNITY SUPPORT FOR STRONGER ANGANWADIS

Anganwadi Centres are the backbone of early childhood care, nutrition, and community-based service delivery in the country. Strengthened delivery of services at these centres requires not only government efforts but also active participation from communities and support under Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives. The theme “Partnering with Community & Corporates for Stronger Anganwadis” reflects the need for a collaborative approach to enhance infrastructure, service quality and community ownership of Anganwadi Centres.

Activities may include –

- a. Awareness drives about Pankhudi Portal of the Ministry on CSR for AWCs.
- b. Encouraging registration on Pankhudi portal
- c. Encourage donation of toys, learning materials, and basic infrastructure support for AWCs.
- d. Sensitize community members to organize events like Tithi Bhoj/ birthdays/anniversaries/ local festivals at AWCs.
- e. Organising Poshan Mela promoting healthy food and stimulating games/sports competition/children's interactions with local corporates and community members.

Note: States and UTs may take up additional activities as per their requirements like Social Media Campaign, IEC Dissemination/ Display at AWCs, Schools and Health facilities, Event with local influencers, sportspersons etc. on vernacular platforms, and Digital Engagement through quiz, poster-making, slogan-writing competitions on Poshan and Early Brain Development.
